ZAKHEERA AI SOLUTIONS (PRIVATE) LIMITED

Leave Policy

Leave types, entitlements, approvals and holidays

Policy ID	ZAI-HR-LV-002
Version	2.2
Effective date	1 January 2024
Policy owner	Human Resources
Applies to	Permanent and probationary employees
Approved by	Chief Executive Officer and Head of Human Resources
HR contact	hr@zakheera.ai | Extension 2200 | HR Helpdesk on the ZakheeraHR portal

1. Purpose and Scope

This policy sets out the types of leave available to ZAKHEERA employees, how leave is earned, requested, approved and recorded, and the public holidays observed. It applies to permanent and probationary employees. Contract employees follow their contract. Interns follow the intern terms in section 12.

2. Leave Year and Entitlement Summary

The leave year runs from 1 January to 31 December. Leave accrues monthly on a pro-rata basis from the joining date and is credited on the first working day of each month. Accrued leave is calculated as days per year x months credited / 12 and rounded to the nearest half day (a quarter day rounds up), so balances are always shown in whole or half days. Half day leave is allowed, which is why a balance can end in .5.

Leave type	Days per year	Paid	Carry forward	Notes
Annual leave	20 working days (22 after 5 years of service)	Yes	Up to 10 days	Planned time off, needs advance approval
Casual leave	8 working days	Yes	No	Short notice personal needs, max 2 days at a time
Sick leave	10 working days	Yes	No	Medical certificate required for 2 or more consecutive days
Maternity leave	120 calendar days	Yes	N/A	Up to 3 times during service
Paternity leave	10 working days	Yes	N/A	Within 60 days of the birth
Marriage leave	5 working days	Yes	N/A	Once during service for own marriage
Bereavement leave	5 days (spouse, child, parent, sibling); 3 days (grandparent, in-law)	Yes	N/A	Starts from date of death
Hajj / Umrah leave	15 working days (Hajj); 7 working days (Umrah)	Hajj paid; Umrah unpaid	N/A	Hajj once after 3 years of service
Study / exam leave	5 working days	Yes	No	For approved degree exams, proof required

Leave type	Days per year	Paid	Carry forward	Notes
Unpaid leave	Up to 30 days per year	No	N/A	Needs Director approval, subject to business needs

3. Annual Leave

- Probationary employees accrue annual leave but may use it only after confirmation, except in emergencies approved by HR.
- Request at least 3 working days ahead for 1 to 2 days, 7 days ahead for 3 to 5 days, and 14 days ahead for more than 5 consecutive days.
- A maximum of 15 consecutive working days may be taken at once without Director approval.
- Up to 10 unused days carry forward to the next year and must be used by 31 March, or they lapse.
- On separation, up to 10 days of accrued unused annual leave are encashed at the daily rate of basic salary (basic divided by 26). Sick and casual leave are never encashed.
- Managers should not unreasonably refuse leave. They may decline or reschedule it because of critical project deadlines and must explain the reason.

4. Casual Leave

Casual leave covers unforeseen personal matters. It cannot be combined with annual leave to exceed 15 consecutive days and cannot be taken for more than 2 consecutive days. Where possible, inform your manager before 10:00 AM on the day and apply in ZakheeraHR within 2 working days.

5. Sick Leave

- Inform your manager as early as possible on the first day of sickness.
- A medical certificate from a registered practitioner is required if sick leave is 2 or more consecutive days, or if the absence is next to a weekend or public holiday.
- Sick leave beyond the 10 day entitlement is adjusted against annual leave, then treated as unpaid.
- For serious illness or surgery requiring more than 15 consecutive days, HR may approve extended medical leave of up to 60 days, using sick leave, then annual leave, then unpaid leave. Medical insurance rules apply separately.

6. Maternity, Paternity and Adoption Leave

- Maternity leave is 120 calendar days on full pay, available to permanent female employees who have completed 6 months of service. Employees with less service receive 60 days of paid leave and may request unpaid leave for the balance.
- Notice of at least 8 weeks before the expected delivery date is required where possible. Leave may start up to 4 weeks before the due date.
- Employees returning from maternity leave may request a hybrid or reduced hours arrangement for up to 6 months, subject to manager and HR approval. Nursing mothers may use the nursing room and take reasonable breaks.
- Paternity leave is 10 working days on full pay, taken within 60 days of the child's birth.
- Adoption leave of 30 calendar days is available to either adoptive parent.

7. Bereavement, Marriage and Religious Leave

Bereavement leave is 5 working days for the death of a spouse, child, parent or sibling, and 3 working days for a grandparent or in-law. Marriage leave is 5 working days once in service, with the invitation card or Nikah Nama on request. Hajj leave of 15 working days is paid once after 3 years of service. Umrah leave of up to 7 working days is unpaid.

8. Public Holidays

ZAKHEERA observes the holidays notified by the Government of Pakistan and the Government of Sindh. The calendar is published by HR each December. Lunar holidays follow moon sighting and may shift.

Holiday	Typical date	Days
Kashmir Solidarity Day	5 February	1
Pakistan Day	23 March	1
Eid ul Fitr	Lunar calendar	3
Labour Day	1 May	1
Eid ul Adha	Lunar calendar	3
Ashura (9th and 10th Muharram)	Lunar calendar	2
Independence Day	14 August	1
Eid Milad un Nabi	Lunar calendar	1
Allama Iqbal Day	9 November	1
Quaid-e-Azam Day / Christmas	25 December	1

If a public holiday falls on a weekend, no substitute holiday is given unless the Government announces one. Employees required to work on a public holiday receive a compensatory day off within 30 days, or double the daily rate if a compensatory day cannot be given.

9. Applying for and Approving Leave

- All leave is requested in ZakheeraHR (web or mobile app) under Leave, then Apply.
- The direct manager approves or rejects within 2 working days. Unanswered requests escalate to the Department Head, then HR.
- Leave of more than 5 days requires the manager and HR Business Partner to approve.
- Leave is not confirmed until approved in the system. Taking unapproved leave is treated as unauthorised absence.
- Half day leave is allowed for annual, casual and sick leave and counts as 0.5 day.

10. Weekends, Holidays and Leave Counting

Weekends and public holidays that fall inside a block of annual or casual leave are not counted as leave. Sick leave that spans a weekend is counted only for working days, unless the medical certificate shows continuous illness, in which case the weekend is still not deducted.

11. Unauthorised Absence

Absence without approval is unpaid and may lead to disciplinary action. Absence for 3 or more consecutive working days without information is treated as abandonment of service after a written notice to the employee's registered address and email, and may result in termination.

12. Interns and Contract Staff

Interns receive 1 day of paid leave per month of internship and public holidays. Contract employees receive the leave stated in their contract. If the contract is silent, they follow this policy pro-rata.

13. Leave Calculation Example

An employee joins on 15 April. April counts as a full month because 16 days of it remain (a part month of 15 days or more counts), so 9 months (April to December) are credited by 31 December. Annual leave accrued is 20 x 9 / 12 = 15 days. Casual leave is 8 x 9 / 12 = 6 days. Sick leave is 10 x 9 / 12 = 7.5 days. An employee who has completed all 12 months by 31 December has the full 20, 8 and 10 days.

Rounding example: an employee with 10 months credited has annual leave of 20 x 10 / 12 = 16.67 days, shown as 16.5 days (rounded to the nearest half day). If they have used 4.5 days, their available annual leave is 16.5 - 4.5 = 12 days. Casual leave is 8 x 10 / 12 = 6.67, shown as 6.5 days.

14. Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Why is my leave balance a decimal such as 12.5?
A: Leave accrues monthly (days per year x months credited / 12) and is rounded to the nearest half day. Half day leave is allowed, so balances are shown in whole or half days.

Q: How is my available leave calculated?
A: Accrued leave to date (days per year x months credited / 12, rounded to the nearest half day) minus the leave you have already used in the calendar year.

Q: How many annual leaves do I get?
A: 20 working days per year, rising to 22 after 5 years of service.

Q: Can I carry forward leaves?
A: Only annual leave, up to 10 days, and it must be used by 31 March. Casual and sick leave do not carry forward.

Q: Do I need a medical certificate for one day of sick leave?
A: No, unless the day is adjacent to a weekend or public holiday. For 2 or more consecutive days a certificate is required.

Q: How long is maternity leave?
A: 120 calendar days on full pay after 6 months of service. With less service, 60 days paid plus optional unpaid leave.

Q: Is paternity leave available?
A: Yes. 10 working days on full pay, to be taken within 60 days of the birth.

Q: Are unused leaves paid when I resign?
A: Up to 10 days of unused annual leave are encashed. Casual and sick leave are not.

Q: How much notice is needed for a 2 week vacation?
A: At least 14 days notice, with manager and HR approval.

Q: Can I take annual leave during probation?
A: It accrues, but it can be used only after confirmation, except for approved emergencies.